Part A argument analysis: cram sheet

AP Seminar · end-of-course exam

Key ideas

1. **A2 and A3** carry 12 of the 15 points; spend most of the time there.
2. A2: explain how the claims connect toward the author's purpose; order is not connection.
3. A3: open with an overall judgment, then judge specific evidence for relevance and credibility.
4. A1: about two sentences naming every part of the thesis.

A2: line of reasoning

6 points

Claim vs evidence	Claim: arguable ("how do you know?"). Evidence answers that; one statement can be both.
Connections	Name the real link: because, so, answers, narrows. Order is not connection.
Pivots	If present, say where the move happens, what changes and why; never invent one.
Close the chain	Last sentence ties the claims to the thesis.

A3: evidence

6 points

Open with a judgment	Overall effectiveness first, matching the real strengths and limits.
Specific pieces	Name the evidence and the exact claim it supports.
Relevance, credibility	Both tied to the claim, from the passage only; a big name alone isn't enough.
Limits	Sample vs conclusion, corroboration, currency in context; missing details limit confidence, they don't prove a flaw.
Hard limit	Evaluating only sources or their reputation cannot score 6.

A1: main argument

3 points

Every part	Position, reason, action and actor, in about two sentences.
Qualification	Keep "not a ban", "only if" and similar limits.
Topic only	Earns 1. Half the thesis earns about 2.

The timed write

about 30 min

min	do this
0 to 8	Read, mark T, C1, C2, E and the major move; star the strongest and weakest evidence.
8 to 10	A1: every part of the thesis.
10 to 19	A2: opening claims and support, the key shift, the conclusion.
19 to 28	A3: overall judgment first, then the pieces the passage warrants.
28 to 30	Reread: complete sentences, nothing bulleted, no invented credentials.

Typed, concise, complete sentences. Practice target 30 to 35; a first try may take 40 to 45. Extra minutes come out of Part B's 90.

Templates (adapt to the passage)

A1 The author argues that [main position] because [main reasons].

A2 Initially, the author establishes [claim] through [evidence/subclaim], which [purpose]. Later, the author shifts from [X] to [Y] to [explain connection]. Finally, [conclusion move] reinforces/qualifies [overall argument] through [support]. No real pivot? Skip the shift; never invent one.

A3 [Specific evidence] supports [claim] because [relevant strength]. However, [specific limitation established by the passage] limits [what can reasonably be concluded], making it [qualified effectiveness judgment]. Use "however" only for a real limitation.

Scoring rules paraphrased from the College Board's 2026 AP Seminar end-of-course exam scoring guidelines; timing targets are practice goals, not official limits. Abbreviations: AP, Advanced Placement; A1 to A3, Part A questions 1 to 3; C1, C2, claim 1, claim 2; T, thesis; E, evidence. valentinoguides.com/seminar-eoc-part-a